

Master Project Guidelines

Introduction

Graduating from the Economics program requires completing a final project. This project consists of a paper that must be done in **groups of 5 students**. **No exceptions** will be allowed.

The paper is supposed to demonstrate your capacity for economic analysis. This can be done in many different ways. The most common (and recommended) one is to use real data to analyze a research question. The question could be something that has not been asked before; it could also be an older question that the latest literature gives a new answer to; or also a question that the literature gives only a theoretical answer.

The paper does not need to be original work. But the paper cannot be a summary of one article from a professional economics journal. We also don't recommend survey papers or several papers since they need a very wide knowledge about the field that is difficult at your stage.

The paper can build on previous work done by members of the group, be that for a bachelor thesis or other courses. But it must be recognizable as a different piece of work by those examining the paper relative to previous work.

The paper is meant to also demonstrate your capacity to work autonomously. You can of course draw on the expertise of faculty for concrete questions that fall into their areas of expertise.

Goals of the Master Project

To evaluate students' success in acquiring new competencies during the Master from a broad perspective, and more specifically:

- Students' knowledge of an area of specialization including state-of-the-art research in that area.

- Students' ability to critically evaluate previously published research of both theoretical and empirical nature using the acquired knowledge.

- Students' **creativity** and **skillfulness** in using theory and data analysis to address **research questions** in Economics, and more specifically, the ability to develop hypotheses, and whenever data availability makes it possible, to design empirical tests of the hypotheses, and implement such tests and interpret the results.

Master projects will be evaluated according to the extent to which they demonstrate the aforementioned competencies.

Important: Master projects will comply with the commonly agreed standards of academic writing in terms of rigor, technical correction, clarity, accuracy, honest

attribution of ideas and thoughts (that is, clear distinction between someone else's thinking and that of the authors, total avoidance of plagiarism), full justification of claims, and avoidance of irrelevant contents.

Implementation

Students will work in groups of **five people**. No exceptions will be allowed.

Two professors and one TA will be assigned to follow the projects. Each group will do:

- 1 informal presentation of approx. 15 minutes in front of the 2 professors and the members of other groups, to explain the project
- 1 informal presentation of approx. 30 minutes in front of a TA and the members of other groups, with the same goal.

After that, there will be 2 individual meetings with the professors and 2 individual meetings with the TA to follow up on the development of the project (these 2 meetings will be with the members of each Master Project group -5 students- with the professor and the TA who follow up the project). In this way, projects can be followed continuously. These sessions will be done during T2 and T3. The dates and times will be notified as early as possible.

Groups will be notified as early as possible of the date and time of their final presentation. **These dates and times cannot be changed under any circumstance.**

Final presentations will take place in **June**, during the last part of the third term (with specific dates to be confirmed at the start of the second term). Attendance of all group members is absolutely compulsory. Therefore, students are advised not to take any commitments for that period. Presentations will last for strictly 15 minutes with an additional 5 minutes for questions.

The evaluation committee will consist of the 2 professors that followed the projects during the term. Grades will be decided after the presentation and released together with the third term grades.

The final grade will consider the following aspects: development, presentation, originality, and literature review. Each student will be graded individually, taking into account the overall quality of the final project as well as their personal contribution and participation in the presentations and discussions with the supervisors and TAs.

Deadlines

- Registration of groups, selection of title and abstract: **January 9th, 2026**.
- Submission of completed projects: **June 2026**.
- Final presentation: **June 2026**.

Style Details

Software: the projects can be written using any word processing software (Microsoft Word, the equivalent in Open Office or LaTeX) but the final version must be a PDF file.

Font: it is recommendable to use one of the following fonts: Times New Roman, Arial, Garamond, Helvetica or any other font that facilitates reading.

Size: - Epigraphs, chapter titles and section titles: 16 points.

- Body of the thesis: 12 points, with 1.5 spacing.
- Figure captions and footnotes: 11 points.

Margins and paragraphs: top, bottom and side margins must be around 3 cm.

The margins cannot be used for footnotes.

The first lines of paragraphs should not be indented.

Leave extra space between paragraphs.

Language: English.

Parts of the Project: The Master Project will necessarily contain the following parts and in the following order:

-Cover: The cover must show the words "MASTER PROJECT", followed by the title (and/or subtitle), the authors, the name of the program and academic year and the GSE logo.

-Contents: table of contents of the project, showing the parts into which it is divided

-Abstract: recommended maximum length: 150 words.

-Introduction, which will include an accurate description of the problem to be analyzed and a motivation of its practical relevance.

-Body of the project: page numbers are required at the bottom of each page.

-Conclusions

-Bibliography: the bibliographical sources used must be documented using a standard citation format.

Total Length: We would expect the paper to have somewhere between 10 and 25 pages of text including tables (as well as references and appendices). The shorter

papers would seem more appropriate for analytical and empirical work on relative narrow/concrete issues. The longer papers seem more appropriate for broader issues. What matters most for the evaluation of the paper is the quality of the substantial work and the clarity of the exposition (not the length of the paper or the size of the group).

Authorship: every project should come with a separate document explaining how the tasks were shared. This should be done in the form of a letter addressed to the Program Director signed by all members of the group.

Codes: it is not necessary to send the codes or data sets.

Meeting: A meeting with the Program Director will be organized during the first term to answer questions about the present document.